UNIVERSITY OF GUYANA

FACULTY of EDUCATION and HUMANITIES

DEPARTMENT of RESEARCH and GRADUATE STUDIES

EFN 5106: The Adolescent Learner

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Topic: The Schools of Psychology.

The approaches of the schools of Psychology namely Psychoanalysis, Behaviourism and Humanism, differ in (1) Their object of study, (2) Their goal of study, and (3) Their method of study, as stated below.

Psychoanalysis

Development is primarily unconscious (that is, beyond awareness) and is heavily colored by emotions.

- A view developed by Sigmund Freud (1856 - !939) that emphasises the interplay of unconscious mental processes in determining human thoughts, feelings, behaviour and personality.
- Erik Erikson (1902 – 1994) says we develop in psychosocial stages. Emphasises developmental change throughout the human lifespan.

The focus of attention is neither the nature or functions of consciousness, neither the stimulus response links that influence behaviour. Relies heavily on the notion of an unconscious mind.
Psychoanalysis – Sigmund Freud theory of personality, which relied on the study of the unconscious mind.
The unconscious mind – A hidden part of the mind harbouring repressed memories that may influence the conscious mind.

The human personality contains, and is greatly influenced by an unconscious mind harbouring repressed (forgotten) memory, which determine conscious thoughts and behaviour. A third level of consciousness, the preconscious, contains thoughts that may not be conscious at a given time, but which is accessible to us (Malin & Birch, 1998).

Human beings are born with a number of instinctual drives that regulate and motivate behaviour. The source of these drives is psychic energy and the most powerful **the libido**, is sexual in nature.

Libido – a form of psychic energy that Freud regarded as sexual in nature, compelling people to act in ways likely to reproduce the species.

Personality consists of three major structures the Id, the Ego and the Superego.

The theory is widely used in the treatment of neuroses and sometimes in the treatment of nonneurotic disorders.

The Aim of psychoanalysis is to explore the individual's unconscious mind in order to understand the dynamics of abnormal behaviour.

Involves transference, the client's projection and displacement of thoughts and feelings onto the analyst (Malin & Birch, 1998).

Behaviourism

- Strong emphasis on how an individual's interaction with environmental events shape change in behaviour throughout the life span
- View the human being as a passive responder to environmental stimuli

Theorists - B F Skinner, Ivan Pavlov, Bandura, Thorndike, Watson.

Is a theory of animal and human learning that only focuses on objectively observable behaviour and discounts mental activities. Behaviour theorists define learning as nothing more than the acquisition of new behaviour.

Conditioning is identified as a universal learning process. There are two types of conditioning, with each yielding different behavioural pattern:
Classical Conditioning (Ivan Pavlov) – occurs when a natural reflex responds to a stimulus. A certain stimulus will produce a specific response.
Behavioural or Operant Conditioning (B.F. Skinner) occurs when a response to a stimulus is reinforced. Basically, is a simple feedback system. If a reward or reinforcement follows the response to a stimulus, then the response becomes more probable in the future.

The theory relies only on observable behavior and describes several universal laws of behaviour. Its positive and negative reinforcement techniques can be very effective in treatment for human disorders such as autism and antisocial behaviour.

Humanism

- Centers on human interests and values and the capacity of individuals to fulfill their potentials.
  People are conscious, self-aware and capable of free choice, self-fulfilment and ethical behaviour.

- Major emphasis is placed on the establishment and development of nurturant, non-threatening situations which would help/allow an individual to develop to their fullest potential.

Theorists – Abraham Maslow and Carl Rogers

Reference

Malin, Tony and Birch, Ann. (1998) Introductory Psychology. New York: Palgrave Publishers Ltd.

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